undertones. In Slovenia, three consecutive elections (2014, 2018 and 2022) have propelled to the position of Prime Minister almost complete novices in politics, with their respective political parties established only a couple of months before elections. There, as seen by Slovenian conservative voters, a practically uncontested and near-complete dominance of politics, business, media and civil society originates in various leftist parties and groups, and has only briefly been interrupted by right-wing leader Janez Janša, often cited for his flirting with Orbán, though he lacked his Hungarian counterpart's majority in the parliament. It was during these short periods of Janša's government that leftist opposition and many NGOs were most vocal about alleged breaches of the rule of law and pressure exerted over the media. At the same time, Mr Janša was also accused of being a Fascist, while simultaneously receiving death threats, both public and in private, which he claimed were not all duly followed up by prosecutors.

Romania and Bulgaria also have their problems with the rule of law, holding them up for years before the gates of Schengen. As late as mid-2022, Politico bluntly put it: 'Bulgaria has been struggling to liberate itself from the influence of a web of oligarch *mafiosi* with deep ties in the parliament and judiciary.'[171]

Such bluntness, used by reporters and politicians alike, is sometimes selective and ignores problems that liberal democracies face in Western Europe too. To say the least, fragmentation and the abandoning of classic mainstream parties have been a phenomenon across Europe, not only in Central Europe. 'Support for democracy has plummeted across the Western world since the fall of the Berlin Wall.'[172] The positive impact of the return of democracy to Europe's East has had only a transitory character – both in the East and the West. The latter is now preoccupied with waves of crisis – terrorism, financial crisis, migration crisis, Brexit, Ukraine, energy crisis. In the east, in Central Europe, the danger for young democracies and populism comes not only (or not as much) from the sources just mentioned, but also from those that are largely unknown to the West. These origins are complex, write Stephen Holmes and Ivan Krastev, 'but they partly lie in the humiliation associated with the uphill struggle to become, at best, an inferior copy of a superior model'.[173] Their analysis of the worldwide populism sees Russians 'cynically simulating the Western democracy', the Chinese 'voraciously borrowing Western technology' and Central